

MOVIE

Death to 2020

★☆☆☆☆ | Charlie Brooker, a name widely regarded for creating the sci-fi anthology series, *Black Mirror*, amassed tons of criticism, when season 5 failed to meet expectations. His next writing venture is what seems to be an unnecessary mockumentary of sorts, recounting the dreadful year of 2020.

Directed by Al Campbell and Alice Matthias, *Death to 2020* takes a "comedic" look back at the bizarre events of the past year, through the voices of some fictional characters, such as a reporter, a scientist, a historian, and even a Karen to name just a few. If you're planning to watch this documentary-style movie, then please, do not be fooled by the brief runtime, as it will be the slowest, longest, and cringiest 71 minutes you'll ever spend. For starters, the performances in this film are over the top and painful, iden-



tical to a YouTube skit almost. Which barely makes any sense, because it curtails a great ensemble cast with the likes of Samuel L. Jackson, Cristin Milioti, and Laurence Fishburne (narrator). The amount of wasted talent here is unimaginable, and could've been better off being part of an actual, serious documentary. The dialogues aren't great

either, ranging from unoriginal, over-used Trump jokes, to age-old meme-y vocabulary stolen from Twitter that's meant to "entice" the Gen-Z audiences. The comedic aspect is non-existent, and any feeble attempt at doing so falls flat. Not even chuckle-worthy.

As for the content itself, the glaring issue is ignorance. Despite being advertised as a satirical, yet somewhat insightful recap for 2020 as a whole, it only focuses on the US and the UK. Every other country or continent is chucked straight out of the narrative. It starts out fine, talking about the real horrors of 2020. But soon, it transcends into a social commentary on the American electoral campaign and a weak, unimaginative montage of Trump's blunders. The only positive for this film would be the way it condensed the events into a simple, easy to understand format... and that's about it!

Death to 2020 completely misses the point it's trying to make. It's unfunny, drags a bit too long, and delves into subjects that aren't monumental. You can skip this without much thought!

TV SERIES

The Innocence Files

★★★★☆ | The relentless machine of the US criminal justice system can at times end up putting people in the incredibly hard position of having to prove their innocence, and this true crime documentary series by Netflix manages to capture exactly that. While shows such as *CSI* and *Dexter* might have glamorised high tech forensic investigations, this show manages to break the illusion and demonstrate that much of the science is bogus, the techniques developed solely to convince juries and judges of the guilt of the accused, and that the so called experts who testify in court cannot really tell the difference between the bite marks



of fish and the bite marks of humans. Even the name of the show positions it squarely against the *Forensic Files*, a long running documentary series celebrating the victories of forensic

investigators who manage to make the streets safer. More details on which bit is science and which bit is bluster, can be found in this month's *dmystify*.

In April 2020, there was another Netflix Original true crime documentary series taking a critical look at the criminal justice system in the United States, *How to Fix a Drug Scandal*, which is at least as good as *The Innocence Files*. The series shows how two crime lab drug chemists who were responsible for identifying contraband in tens of thousands of cases, were clearing case work at improbable rates without proper testing, culminating in the largest mass dismissal of cases in US history. Step by step, the documentary expertly traces the efforts of lawyers at unravelling a ring of corruption that extended beyond the lab workers to the police personnel working on cases, who were happy as long as they got to put people in jail. *How to Fix a Drug Scandal* is a perfect follow up if you like *The Innocence Files*.